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MAKING DEMOCRACY MORE GOVERNABLE



*Dharma Rājyam and
the Post-Liberal Crisis*



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*Dharmo viśvasya jagataḥ pratiṣṭhā
Dharma is the foundation of the entire universe.*

Abstract

Across much of the democratic world, questions concerning governability have assumed renewed centrality. Leadership instability, fragmented electorates, performative politics, declining social trust, and the erosion of long-term strategic coherence increasingly characterise even historically stable democracies. Britain's post-Brexit turbulence, repeated changes in political leadership, and the rise of grievance-driven populism represent not isolated anomalies, but symptoms of a broader civilisational transition within liberal societies.

This paper argues that the contemporary crisis of governability cannot be understood merely as a problem of institutions, administration, or economics. Rather, it reflects a deeper imbalance within the philosophical foundations of governance itself. The neoliberal phase of political evolution historically performed an important corrective function by liberating enterprise, decentralising initiative, and breaking institutional stagnation. Yet in doing so, it also weakened many of the behavioural, ethical, cultural, and affective disciplines necessary for sustaining democratic cohesion and long-term governability.

The resulting crisis is therefore not merely procedural but civilisational. Modern democracies increasingly struggle not with freedom itself, but with disciplined freedom. They have successfully expanded individual autonomy and market dynamism without adequately cultivating the social restraint, ethical leadership, civic moderation, and integrative frameworks necessary to govern liberated societies across time. Procedural legitimacy alone increasingly proves insufficient where shared civic meaning, behavioural moderation, and experiential coherence steadily weaken.

In response, this paper explores *Dharma Rājyam* not as a theological doctrine or nostalgic return to pre-modernity, but as a governance principle centred on proportionate authority, disciplined freedom, ethical restraint, pluralistic legitimacy, and civilisational continuity. Drawing upon the classical Indian conceptual vocabulary of the *guṇas*, namely *tamas*, *rajas*, and *sattva*, the paper

proposes a dynamic understanding of governability as continuous democratic balancing rather than static institutional equilibrium. It further argues that democratic stability ultimately depends not only upon institutional design, but upon the cultivation of civic cultures capable of harmonising plurality within a broader framework of legitimacy, restraint, and shared civilisational participation.

The central proposition advanced is that the defining political challenge of the twenty-first century is no longer liberation from authority alone, but the reconstruction of legitimate authority, disciplined freedom, and civic coherence after liberation.

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I. Introduction: Governability and Democratic Fragmentation

In recent years, the vocabulary of democratic crisis has undergone a subtle but profound transformation. Earlier anxieties concerning inequality, globalisation, institutional inefficiency, or economic stagnation have progressively given way to a deeper and more unsettling concern: whether modern democracies themselves are becoming difficult to govern.

The repeated invocation of ‘ungovernability’ in public discourse is no longer confined to fragile or transitional states. It increasingly applies to advanced democracies once regarded as politically stable and institutionally resilient. Britain provides perhaps the clearest contemporary illustration of this phenomenon. Since the Brexit referendum of 2016, the United Kingdom has experienced unusual levels of leadership instability, policy incoherence, factional polarisation, and electoral fragmentation. Prime ministers have changed with unusual rapidity. Political parties frequently struggle to sustain broad coalitional legitimacy. Governance often appears reactive rather than strategic, performative rather than disciplined.¹

Yet Britain is not alone. The United States faces escalating ideological polarisation and declining institutional trust. France has witnessed repeated eruptions of legitimacy crisis amidst growing fragmentation between metropolitan elites and peripheral social blocs. Italy continues to experience chronic governmental instability. Israel frequently confronts tensions between democratic pluralism and civilisational identity. Across much of the democratic world, the behavioural ecology that once sustained stable liberal governance appears progressively weaker.

These developments have generated extensive commentary attributing democratic instability to technological disruption, demographic pressures, bureaucratic rigidity, fiscal constraints, media ecosystems, or globalisation.

¹ Robert Shrimsley, “‘Ungovernable’ Britain Has Had Woeful Leaders,” *Financial Times*, May 15, 2026.

While each contributes to contemporary instability, none sufficiently explains the deeper behavioural and civilisational character of the present crisis.

What appears increasingly visible across democratic societies is not merely institutional fatigue, but the erosion of disciplined statecraft itself. Political leadership is progressively shaped by short-term electoral signalling, emotional mobilisation, factional incentives, and performative communication cycles. Strategic continuity weakens. Public discourse fragments into grievance blocs. Shared civic identities become fragile.

The crisis, therefore, may not fundamentally concern institutional capacity alone. It may instead reflect a deeper exhaustion within the philosophy of governance that shaped the post-Cold War democratic order.

The central argument of this paper is that liberal democratic societies frequently confront a crisis of governability because the expansion of procedural freedom and market dynamism has outpaced the ethical, behavioural, and civilisational disciplines necessary to sustain social cohesion across time. Neoliberalism successfully liberated economic and individual energies from rigid institutional constraints, yet it simultaneously weakened many of the integrative norms through which democratic societies historically maintained moderation, continuity, and legitimacy. The resulting challenge is therefore not the rejection of freedom, but the reconstruction of disciplined freedom within a pluralistic democratic civilisation.

Against this backdrop, the paper explores *Dharma Rājyam* as a post-liberal framework for understanding governability. *Dharma Rājyam* is not presented as theocracy, cultural revivalism, or anti-modern reaction. Rather, it is examined as a governance principle centred on proportionate authority, disciplined freedom, ethical stewardship, civilisational balance, and pluralistic legitimacy.

Ultimately, the paper argues that the great political challenge of the twenty-first century is no longer liberation from authority alone, but the reconstruction of legitimate authority after liberation. While grounded in Indian civilisational vocabulary, the argument advanced here is not confined to India alone. Rather, it

explores whether certain *dhārmic* insights concerning restraint, plurality, ethical participation, and civilisational continuity may illuminate wider democratic challenges confronting pluralistic societies globally.

II. Beyond Institutional Explanations

Contemporary analyses of democratic instability generally begin with institutional explanations. Governments are described as ineffective because bureaucracies are rigid, fiscal pressures severe, populations ageing, or technological disruptions rapid. Political fragmentation is attributed to constitutional weaknesses, failures of economic management, declining party discipline, or algorithmically amplified media ecosystems.

These explanations are not incorrect. Yet they are incomplete.

A purely institutional diagnosis assumes that governance is fundamentally procedural, and that societies become governable primarily through improved administration, regulatory efficiency, or better policy design. Such approaches often presume that the behavioural and civilisational conditions necessary for democratic order remain intact.

Increasingly, this assumption appears questionable. Contemporary political thinkers such as Kishore Mahbubani similarly argue that long-term governability depends not merely upon procedural institutions, but upon the deeper cultural and civilisational capacities through which societies sustain social trust, behavioural discipline, and collective coherence.²

Across many democracies, the visible crisis is not merely administrative inefficiency but the erosion of disciplined political culture itself. Electoral cycles shorten strategic horizons. Leaders are selected frequently for communicative agility and symbolic appeal rather than seriousness of statecraft. Public discourse becomes emotionally charged and permanently mobilised. Politics transforms into performance.

² Kishore Mahbubani, *The Great Convergence: Asia, the West, and the Logic of One World* (New York: PublicAffairs, 2013), 45–68.

Recent developments in the United States further illustrate how democratic fragmentation increasingly operates through emotional intensification rather than integrative civic participation. The resurgence of disputes surrounding voting rights, racial representation, and electoral districting after recent judicial interventions has revived civil rights anxieties associated with the Selma era. Particularly significant is the testimony of veteran civil rights participants who describe contemporary politics less as democratic disagreement than as a condition of escalating hostility, fear, and mutual delegitimisation.³

Institutions can distribute authority, coordinate policy, and regulate behaviour. But institutions alone cannot reliably reproduce civic restraint, ethical seriousness, social moderation, long-term stewardship, or civilisational cohesion. Democracy ultimately depends upon behavioural and moral foundations that precede formal procedure. Francis Fukuyama similarly argues that political order depends not merely upon procedural legitimacy, but also upon social trust, institutional coherence, and the behavioural capacities through which societies sustain legitimacy across time.⁴ Alexis de Tocqueville recognised this problem early when he argued that democratic societies survive not merely through laws but through ‘habits of the heart’ that cultivate moderation and civic responsibility.⁵

Liberal democratic systems historically relied upon shared norms of moderation, civic obligation, mutual restraint, and broad cultural continuity. However, as political and economic systems progressively prioritised expressive individualism, market-driven organisation, and self-assertion, the integrative disciplines sustaining democratic order weakened.

The resulting instability now manifests through fragmented electorates, grievance mobilisation, declining social trust, performative populism, weakening national cohesion, and the collapse of broad coalitional legitimacy.

³ Reuters, “US Civil Rights Veterans See History Repeating After Court Guts Voting Rights Act,” *The Hindu*, May 19, 2026.

⁴ Francis Fukuyama, *Political Order and Political Decay: From the Industrial Revolution to the Globalization of Democracy* (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2014), 437–71; Francis Fukuyama, *Trust: The Social Virtues and the Creation of Prosperity* (New York: Free Press, 1995).

⁵ Alexis de Tocqueville, *Democracy in America*, trans. Harvey Mansfield and Delba Winthrop (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2000), 489–512.

Governability therefore emerges not merely as a question of institutional design, but as a civilisational problem concerning the behavioural capacity of societies to sustain proportion, restraint, and continuity amidst expanding freedom.

III. Neoliberalism and the Expansion of Freedom

Any serious analysis of the contemporary democratic crisis must avoid retrospective simplification. The neoliberal turn did not emerge arbitrarily. In Britain it manifested through Thatcherism, in the United States through Reaganism, and in India through the post-1991 programme of Liberalisation, Privatisation, and Globalisation (LPG). It arose as a historically necessary response to genuine structural stagnation within mid-twentieth-century political economies.

By the 1970s, many Western democracies were experiencing symptoms of institutional sclerosis: over-centralised state structures, excessive union dominance, declining productivity, bureaucratic inertia, inflationary pressures, and diminishing economic dynamism.⁶

The neoliberal moment represented a corrective.

Markets were liberalised. Entrepreneurial initiative expanded. Economic activity decentralised. Bureaucratic rigidities weakened. Innovation accelerated. Individual aspiration and social mobility gained renewed legitimacy.

The philosophical core of this transformation lay in redefining freedom primarily as liberation from excessive constraint. Friedrich Hayek's defence of liberty powerfully articulated this vision of decentralised order emerging through free individuals and market coordination.⁷ Historically, these developments were neither trivial nor wholly misguided. In many societies, neoliberal reforms restored productive energy and institutional dynamism.

Yet every civilisational correction generates secondary consequences.

⁶ Daniel Yergin and Joseph Stanislaw, *The Commanding Heights: The Battle for the World Economy* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 1998), 96–132.

⁷ Friedrich A. Hayek, *The Constitution of Liberty* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1960), 11–35.

Over time, the expansion of freedom as unconstrained choice weakened many of the behavioural and institutional disciplines necessary for long-term democratic cohesion. As market logic permeated social life, older integrative structures such as community, civic obligation, ethical restraint, institutional seriousness, and shared identity gradually weakened.⁸

Politics itself frequently absorbed market dynamics. Leaders became brands. Citizens became segmented constituencies. Governance became performative. Public discourse became transactional and emotionally reactive.

The deeper limitation of neoliberalism was therefore not merely economic, but civilisational in its consequences. It assumed that liberated individuals and decentralised markets would spontaneously generate sustainable social order.

But liberation alone cannot generate durable order. Markets can efficiently coordinate incentives. They cannot independently cultivate restraint, moderation, ethical obligation, or civilisational continuity.

IV. The Crisis of Disciplined Freedom

The emerging instability across democratic societies now suggests that modern political systems solved the problem of liberation before solving the problem of disciplined liberation.

The liberal democratic project historically focused on protecting individuals from excessive concentrations of authority. Its institutional architecture therefore prioritised rights, decentralisation, procedural safeguards, and individual autonomy.

Yet as democratic systems steadily prioritised expressive individualism and market-mediated freedom, they also weakened the behavioural disciplines that stabilise pluralistic societies.

⁸ Charles Taylor, *Sources of the Self: The Making of the Modern Identity* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1989).

Democratic legitimacy across contemporary societies disperses into unstable identity formations and emotionally mobilised constituencies. Political parties struggle to maintain broad coalitional coherence. Electoral mandates become narrow, unstable, and emotionally polarised.

Rather than integrating diverse interests into shared national frameworks, politics frequently amplifies fragmentation itself. Democracy becomes less a mechanism of negotiated order and more a theatre of competing resentments. Fragmentation simultaneously undermines long-term policy continuity.

The behavioural culture of political leadership also undergoes transformation. Emotional resonance becomes more politically valuable than disciplined judgment. Slogans replace statecraft. Governance becomes performative rather than strategic.

The consequence is a paradoxical condition: societies become increasingly free yet progressively more difficult to govern.

The problem is not freedom itself. The problem is that freedom without behavioural restraint, ethical moderation, and integrative civic culture gradually destabilises the conditions necessary for democratic continuity.

V. Fragmentation and the Limits of Procedural Liberalism

The deeper difficulty facing many contemporary democracies is that procedural legitimacy alone no longer appears sufficient to sustain civilisational cohesion. Liberal democratic systems historically assumed that expanding representation, rights, and participation would gradually strengthen social integration and political stability. Yet over time, democratic participation itself often becomes a vehicle for fragmentation, grievance mobilisation, and antagonistic identity consolidation rather than shared civic belonging.

Indian anti-colonial thinkers frequently criticised British governance through the phrase 'divide and rule,' recognising that durable political control often operated

through the segmentation of civilisational cohesion into administratively and electorally differentiated blocs. Colonial governance progressively transformed fluid social identities into bounded political constituencies organised through census categories, communal representation, and differentiated institutional participation.⁹

Mahatma Gandhi's response to such fragmentation was not centralised coercion, but integrative non-cooperation rooted in shared civic participation across religions, regions, castes, and social categories. The freedom movement therefore also represented an attempt to reconstruct civilisational cohesion amidst politically institutionalised fragmentation.

Contemporary democratic fragmentation cannot be simplistically equated with colonial rule. Yet the deeper tension within the modern representative system is revealing: mechanisms intended to secure inclusion may also intensify social fragmentation when political life becomes organised around competitive identities, grievance mobilisation, and antagonistic constituencies rather than broader frameworks of civic integration.

The contemporary American experience demonstrates that fragmentation can persist even within formally stable constitutional systems. The growing polarisation surrounding race, electoral legitimacy, demographic representation, and judicial authority reveals how procedural continuity may coexist with weakening civic solidarity.¹⁰

This development exposes an important limitation within procedural liberalism. Liberal democratic systems depend upon pre-political moral and cultural disciplines that liberalism itself cannot easily generate. Alasdair MacIntyre's critique of modern moral fragmentation and Patrick Deneen's argument

⁹ Bipan Chandra et al., *India's Struggle for Independence* (New Delhi: Penguin, 1989), 131–56; Bernard S. Cohn, *Colonialism and Its Forms of Knowledge: The British in India* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1996), 57–75.

¹⁰ Reuters, "US Civil Rights Veterans See History Repeating."

concerning the self-undermining tendencies of liberalism illuminate this problem from different directions.¹¹

Liberal democratic thought derived much of its moral force from universal conceptions of dignity and equality, yet translating formal equality into durable civic cohesion has proven considerably more difficult.

Without civic moderation, reciprocity, shared belonging, and ethical seriousness, procedural freedom alone gradually transforms representation into fragmentation. Liberal democratic systems successfully institutionalised equal dignity and procedural freedom. Yet they developed a comparatively thinner account of how differentiated identities, social functions, aspirations, and competing interests might remain meaningfully ordered within a shared civilisational framework across time. As older integrative frameworks weakened, democratic participation increasingly struggled to transform plurality into durable civic coherence.

At a deeper philosophical level, this fragmentation may also reflect a tension internal to modern liberalism itself. Liberal societies increasingly encourage individuals and groups to recognise, assert, and politically mobilise their distinct identities and interests. Yet liberal universalism simultaneously seeks to flatten these differences within abstract frameworks of formal equality and procedural uniformity. The result is often a paradoxical condition in which difference is continuously intensified politically while lacking an integrative civilisational framework capable of harmonising plurality within a larger order. The consequence is frequently a politics of perpetual antagonism in which democratic participation steadily amplifies fragmentation rather than civic integration.

By contrast, the *dhārmic* conception of society does not erase difference. Through the principle of *svadharma* (one's situated responsibilities and mode of participation), differentiated individuals and communities contribute to the

¹¹ Alasdair MacIntyre, *After Virtue*, 3rd ed. (Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 2007), 236–63; Patrick J. Deneen, *Why Liberalism Failed* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2018), 27–61.

maintenance of a larger ethical and civilisational order. Diversity thereby becomes not fragmentation, but ordered participation within a sustaining whole.

At the same time, the uneven experience of democratic fragmentation across societies suggests that institutions alone do not determine governability. Nordic democracies, despite high levels of liberalisation and individual freedom, continue to exhibit comparatively stronger social trust, civic moderation, institutional seriousness, and behavioural restraint. Their relative stability reinforces the argument that democratic governability depends not merely upon procedural structures, but upon deeper ethical and cultural disciplines within society itself.

VI. Governability as Dynamic Equilibrium

One of the central limitations of modern political analysis is its tendency to treat governability as a static institutional condition. Yet civilisations rarely operate through static equilibrium.

Governability is better understood as a dynamic balancing process sustained through continuous adjustment between competing forces: freedom and order, authority and restraint, innovation and continuity, dynamism and stability.

This insight may be illuminated through the classical Indian conceptual vocabulary of the *guṇas*: *tamas*, *rajas*, and *sattva*.

Tamas (inertia, rigidity, and stagnation) represents excessive proceduralism, institutional lethargy, and resistance to adaptation.

Rajas (activity, ambition, competition, and dynamism) represents movement, expansion, aspiration, and intensified social energy.

Sattva (clarity, balance, restraint, and harmonisation) represents proportionate integration capable of aligning freedom and dynamism within broader civilisational continuity.

Many contemporary democracies increasingly appear characterised by prolonged *rājasic* escalation: permanently stimulated media environments, emotionally intensified public discourse, performative leadership cultures, and grievance politics.

A *sāttvic* political order does not suppress freedom or ambition. It aligns them within broader civilisational continuity and ethical proportion. From this perspective, difference itself is not the source of democratic instability. Civilisations have always contained plurality of interests, temperaments, identities, and functions. The deeper challenge concerns whether such differences remain ordered within a shared framework of legitimacy, restraint, and continuity. *Dharma*, in this sense, does not eliminate plurality. It seeks to harmonise plurality without collapsing it into either fragmentation or enforced uniformity.

Governability is therefore not permanent stability imposed from above. It is the continuous civilisational capacity to rebalance competing forces before fragmentation or rigidity become destructive.

VII. India Through the Guṇa Framework

The post-independence evolution of India offers an illuminating case through which to examine the relationship between political economy and civilisational balance.

The decades following independence were shaped by scarcity, strategic vulnerability, and the imperatives of national consolidation. Centralised planning initially provided coherence and stability.

Yet over time, the developmental state increasingly acquired *tāmasic* characteristics: bureaucratic rigidity, procedural inertia, over-centralisation, and restricted initiative.

The liberalisation reforms initiated in 1991 represented a profound psychological transformation. Markets opened. Enterprise expanded.

Aspirational mobility accelerated. Indian society experienced a dramatic increase in entrepreneurial energy and self-confidence. A new *rājasic* phase emerged.

Historically, this transition was necessary.

However, as with all *rājasic* expansions, secondary distortions also emerged: consumerist aspiration, status anxiety, performative success culture, emotional political mobilisation, and social fragmentation.

The challenge increasingly became not how to generate energy, but how to govern energy without suppressing it.

Contemporary discourse surrounding *Amrit Kaal*, the twenty-five-year period between the seventy-fifth anniversary of Indian independence in 2022 (*Azadi ka Amrit Mahotsav*) and the centenary of independence in 2047, may be interpreted philosophically as an aspiration toward greater *sāttvic* balance: disciplined capability, continuity with civilisational memory, strategic confidence, and harmonisation between prosperity and cohesion.¹²

VIII. Dharma Rājyam as a Post-Liberal Framework

Dharma Rājyam is frequently misunderstood either as theocratic aspiration or nostalgic revivalism. Both interpretations are inadequate.

Dharma Rājyam, as explored in this paper, is not theocratic rule. Nor is it a rejection of democratic modernity, markets, or institutional pluralism. Rather, it is a governance principle centred on proportionate authority, disciplined freedom, ethical restraint, pluralistic legitimacy, and civilisational continuity.

At its deepest level, the Indian conception of *dharma* has often been expressed through two classical formulations: *Dhārayati iti dharmah* ('that which sustains and upholds order') and *Dharmo rakṣati rakṣitaḥ* ('*dharma* protects those who uphold it'). Together, these formulations illuminate *dharma* not merely as

¹² Narendra Modi, "Address to the Nation from the Red Fort on the 75th Independence Day," Prime Minister's Office, Government of India, August 15, 2022.

religious doctrine, but as a reciprocal principle of ethical and civilisational continuity sustained through responsible participation by rulers, institutions, and society alike.

Under this framework, governability depends not merely upon state authority, but upon the collective willingness of society to uphold the disciplines necessary for sustaining legitimate freedom across time.

Modern liberalism generally defines freedom negatively as freedom from interference or external authority. *Dharma* introduces a different conception.

Freedom is not merely absence of restraint. It is disciplined participation within a larger order. Within the *dhārmic* framework, unity and diversity operate at different levels simultaneously. At the deepest level of being, all existence remains interconnected. At the practical level of social life, however, plurality, differentiated functions, and varying dispositions remain unavoidable realities. *Dharma* therefore seeks neither the erasure of difference nor its absolutisation, but the alignment of plurality within a broader civilisational order.

Under this framework, genuine freedom involves self-mastery, ethical restraint, responsibility toward continuity, and alignment between individual aspiration and collective order. *Dharma* therefore functions not merely as a restraint upon rulers, but as an ethical discipline cultivated within society itself.

Within the broader Indian philosophical framework, *dharma* regulates the legitimate pursuit of *artha* (material flourishing) and *kāma* (desire, aspiration, and enjoyment). The problem is not prosperity, ambition, or differentiated aspiration as such, but their disconnection from ethical proportion and civilisational responsibility. Participation within a properly ordered society gradually cultivates self-restraint, maturity, and reflective awareness. In this sense, disciplined freedom becomes not merely a mechanism of political order, but a pathway toward inner refinement. The long-term aim of a *dhārmic* civilisation is not the suppression of individuality, but the harmonisation of individual aspiration within an expanding conception of collective welfare.

Such harmonisation, however, cannot be sustained through coercive uniformity. A *dhārmic* civilisational order must therefore reconcile ethical cohesion with genuine pluralism.

Any viable post-liberal framework must therefore address pluralism. A modern *Dharma Rājyam* cannot depend upon theological uniformity or enforced cultural conformity. Nor can civilisational cohesion become a justification for majoritarian domination.

A democratic civilisational order remains legitimate only when minority rights, constitutional safeguards, institutional independence, and peaceful dissent remain protected.

Scholars of legal pluralism such as Werner Menski and Masaji Chiba similarly argue that sustainable legal and political systems emerge not through procedural institutions alone, but through dynamic interaction between formal law, social norms, ethical traditions, and lived civilisational frameworks.¹³

IX. Prajā and the Shared Responsibility of Governability

A democratic civilisation cannot remain governable through institutional design or leadership culture alone. Governability also depends upon the behavioural disposition of the *prajā* (citizens) themselves. Freedom can remain sustainable only when citizens possess sufficient restraint, responsibility, moderation, and civic seriousness to sustain legitimate order amidst plurality and disagreement.

Classical Indian political thought did not treat *dharma* as an obligation imposed unilaterally by the ruler. *Dharma* governed reciprocal obligations within society as a whole. The ruler, the governing party, the opposition, institutions, and citizens each possessed responsibilities necessary for sustaining social continuity and legitimate order.

¹³ Werner Menski, *Comparative Law in a Global Context: The Legal Systems of Asia and Africa* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006); Masaji Chiba, *Legal Pluralism: Toward a General Theory Through Japanese Legal Culture* (Tokyo: Tokai University Press, 1989).

Democratic systems implicitly assume forms of civic self-regulation without which procedural freedom itself becomes unstable. Yet much of modern political thought under-theorises the ethical responsibilities of citizenship, focusing extensively upon institutional constraints upon power while devoting comparatively less attention to the behavioural disciplines required for sustaining democratic continuity. A governable democratic civilisation depends not merely upon rights-conscious citizens, but upon citizens capable of restraint, reciprocity, proportion, and responsible participation amidst disagreement.

The contemporary democratic crisis increasingly reveals what occurs when these reciprocal disciplines weaken simultaneously. Governments become performative. Oppositions increasingly mobilise grievance without responsibility for continuity. Citizens themselves become vulnerable to permanent emotional agitation, factional antagonism, and civic exhaustion.

The *guṇa* framework also illuminates the behavioural condition of democratic society itself. *Tāmasic* tendencies within the *prajā* manifest as apathy, dependency, passivity, and withdrawal from civic responsibility. *Rājasic* tendencies manifest as grievance mobilisation, hyper-competition, performative outrage, emotional polarisation, and perpetual agitation. *Sāttvic* civic culture, by contrast, cultivates moderation, ethical participation, disciplined disagreement, and responsible freedom.

Governability therefore depends not only upon the restraint of rulers, but also upon the self-restraint of society itself. No democratic civilisation can remain stable if freedom expands faster than the ethical disciplines required to sustain it.

X. Democracy, Arājakam, and the Limits of Polarisation

Contemporary political discourse often frames governance through simplistic binaries: democracy versus authoritarianism, freedom versus control, liberalism versus centralisation.

Yet such binaries obscure a deeper question: which political arrangements sustain legitimacy, continuity, cohesion, and restraint across time?

This paper does not argue against democracy. Its argument is not that democracy fails, but that democracy requires ethical and behavioural foundations stronger than procedure alone. Democracy remains the most desirable political condition because it permits correction, plurality, distributed participation, and peaceful transition of power. However, democracy alone does not automatically guarantee governability.

Fareed Zakaria similarly warned that democratic participation alone does not necessarily produce liberal constitutional stability, civic moderation, or governable political order. Electoral legitimacy without sufficient institutional restraint and civic cohesion may itself contribute to fragmentation and instability.¹⁴

Democratic systems remain stable only when supported simultaneously by disciplined statecraft, cohesive civic culture, ethical restraint within both leadership and society, and integrative norms capable of moderating fragmentation. Where these weaken, democratic fragmentation intensifies.

The result may not immediately be dictatorship, but something potentially more destabilising: *arājakam*, the erosion of coherent order itself.

Arājakam does not necessarily imply total collapse. Rather, it describes a condition in which legitimacy fragments, authority weakens, emotional mobilisation intensifies, and continuity steadily erodes.

The challenge, therefore, is not merely institutional stability, but the restoration of the affective and civilisational coherence through which democratic societies experience public life as legitimate, meaningful, and proportionate. If governability ultimately depends upon behavioural moderation and affective

¹⁴ Fareed Zakaria, *The Future of Freedom: Illiberal Democracy at Home and Abroad*, rev. ed. (New York: W. W. Norton, 2007), 17–42.

coherence, then aesthetic traditions become politically relevant not indirectly, but civilisationally.

XI. Naṭarāja, Civic Rasa, and the Rhythmic Nature of Civilisation

The Naṭarāja image placed at the beginning of this paper symbolises this deeper conception of civilisational rhythm and dynamic equilibrium. Modern political thought often seeks permanent institutional solutions to fundamentally dynamic civilisational problems. Yet societies do not remain static. They continuously oscillate between order and fragmentation, discipline and excess, integration and disintegration.

Within the Indian philosophical imagination, the iconography of Naṭarāja offers a profound metaphor for this reality.

Naṭarāja's *tāṇḍava* symbolises a civilisational order sustained not through immobility, but through rhythmic balancing amidst continuous creation, preservation, dissolution, and renewal.¹⁵

This metaphor deepens the conception of governability developed throughout this paper. Governability is not permanent stillness imposed upon society. Nor is it the suppression of dynamism. Rather, it is the continuous civilisational capacity to rebalance destabilising energies before fragmentation becomes destructive.

Yet governability depends not only upon structural balance, but also upon experiential legitimacy. Political orders remain stable not merely because institutions function procedurally, but because citizens continue to experience public life as coherent, proportionate, meaningful, and civilisationally intelligible.

In this sense, democratic societies require what may be described as civic *rasa*: a shared experiential atmosphere through which plurality, disagreement, competition, and political participation remain integrated within a broader sense

¹⁵ Ananda K. Coomaraswamy, *The Dance of Śiva: Essays on Indian Art and Culture* (New York: Noonday Press, 1957), 56–66.

of legitimacy and belonging. Democratic legitimacy may therefore be understood not merely procedurally, but aesthetically and affectively. The governing party bears responsibility for sustaining this civic *rasa* through proportionate and disciplined governance, while the democratic opposition performs an equally necessary role by identifying emerging *rasa*-gaps where public life loses balance, legitimacy, responsiveness, or ethical seriousness. Abhinavagupta understood *rasa* not merely as emotional stimulation, but as a refined and universalised experience capable of harmonising individual consciousness within a larger aesthetic order.¹⁶

The erosion of civic *rasa* increasingly characterises many contemporary democracies. Public discourse becomes permanently agitated, politics emotionally exhausting, outrage replaces deliberation, and spectacle replaces seriousness. Citizens no longer experience governance as harmonising public life, but as intensifying fragmentation itself.

Democratic participation continues formally, yet the experiential texture of public life becomes emotionally exhausting rather than socially integrating. The recurring language of fear, hostility, and permanent agitation now visible across multiple democracies suggests that many societies are losing the affective coherence necessary for sustaining shared political life over time.¹⁷

A governable civilisation therefore depends not merely upon institutional efficiency or political authority, but upon the capacity of public life to sustain experiential coherence amidst conflict and plurality.

XII. Conclusion: Beyond Neoliberalism

The neoliberal phase of political evolution performed an important historical role. It restored dynamism, expanded enterprise, decentralised initiative, and weakened rigid structures of stagnation.

¹⁶ Abhinavagupta, *Abhinavabhāratī*, trans. Raniero Gnoli, *The Aesthetic Experience According to Abhinavagupta* (Rome: Istituto Italiano per il Medio ed Estremo Oriente, 1956).

¹⁷ Reuters, “US Civil Rights Veterans See History Repeating.”

Yet the same processes also weakened many of the behavioural, ethical, and civilisational disciplines necessary for sustaining democratic cohesion across time. The result is a paradox visible across advanced democracies: societies become more individually free yet increasingly difficult to govern.

The defining political challenge of the twenty-first century is therefore no longer liberation from authority alone, but the reconstruction of legitimate authority and disciplined civic culture after liberation. This reconstruction cannot occur through authoritarian suppression or nostalgic rejection of modernity.

It requires a renewed civilisational framework capable of reconciling liberty with restraint, plurality with coherence, dynamism with continuity, and capability with stewardship.

Dharma Rājyam offers one possible conceptual vocabulary for such a synthesis. Not as theocracy. Not as anti-modern reaction. But as a continuous civilisational effort to maintain balance between freedom and order, authority and restraint, ambition and responsibility, prosperity and legitimacy.

Ultimately, what makes a democratic civilisation governable is not power alone, but the disciplined and proportionate exercise of freedom within a society capable of sustaining legitimacy, restraint, coherence, and continuity across time.

Epilogue: Civic Rasa and Democratic Civilisation

If the crisis of contemporary democracy is fundamentally civilisational rather than merely procedural, then the restoration of governability cannot occur solely through institutional reform. It also requires the reconstruction of behavioural coherence, ethical restraint, emotional moderation, and shared civic meaning.

This raises a deeper question: how are such capacities cultivated within society itself?

The *Nāṭyaśāstra* offers an important civilisational insight in this regard. *Nāṭya* (dramatic performance tradition) was never conceived merely as entertainment. Sage Bharata describes *nāṭya* as a comprehensive social art intended to educate,

refine, harmonise, and elevate collective consciousness.¹⁸ Its purpose was simultaneously aesthetic, ethical, pedagogical, and civilisational.

Within this framework, *rasa* becomes especially significant. *Rasa* is not merely emotional stimulation. Through aesthetic universalisation, *sādhāraṇīkaraṇa*, personal emotion becomes refined into contemplative experience. Individual agitation is transformed into reflective participation within a larger experiential order.¹⁹

In civilisational terms, *sādhāraṇīkaraṇa* offers an alternative to both atomised individualism and coercive collectivism by harmonising plurality without erasing difference.

Many democratic societies today operate within environments of permanent *rājasīc* escalation: outrage cycles, algorithmic agitation, grievance mobilisation, performative political discourse, and emotional overstimulation.

Nāṭya offers an alternative civic logic. The disciplined training of body, speech, gesture, rhythm, attention, and emotional modulation cultivates restraint without suppression, expressiveness without chaos, and intensity without fragmentation.

The *nāṭya* practitioner therefore becomes more than a performer. The practitioner becomes a carrier of civic rhythm and behavioural refinement.

This transmission occurs not through ideological instruction or political propaganda, but through embodied demonstration of proportion, attention, dignity, and harmonisation. Unlike propaganda, which seeks emotional manipulation toward predetermined political outcomes, *nāṭya* refines emotional experience through aesthetic contemplation and universalisation. Its purpose is not political conformity, but cultivation of the inner capacities necessary for ethical participation within collective life. In this sense, *nāṭya* strengthens democratic civilisation not by eliminating disagreement, but by moderating the

¹⁸ Bharata, *Nāṭyaśāstra*, trans. Manomohan Ghosh, 2 vols. (Calcutta: Asiatic Society, 1951–1961).

¹⁹ Abhinavagupta, *Abhinavabhāratī*.

psychological fragmentation through which disagreement becomes socially destructive.

Historically, the *sabhā* was not merely a venue of spectatorship, but a site of shared affective participation through which social tensions could be absorbed into broader civilisational continuity.

This becomes especially significant in an age of accelerated emotional stimulation and diminishing civic reflection.

A democratic civilisation cannot remain governable if public life continuously amplifies fear, hostility, agitation, and resentment without simultaneously cultivating spaces of reflective integration.

In this context, *nāṭya* may be understood as a form of non-coercive civic pedagogy. Its task is not political indoctrination, nor escapist aestheticism. Rather, it helps cultivate the behavioural and emotional capacities necessary for sustaining democratic civilisation itself: attentiveness, restraint, proportion, empathy, disciplined participation, and continuity amidst plurality.

This insight also clarifies the deeper meaning of *Dharma Rājyam* within a democratic age. *Dharma* cannot be sustained through law alone. Nor can civilisational coherence be maintained through state power alone.

A society remains governable only when ethical discipline and aesthetic sensitivity continue reproducing behavioural moderation within public life itself.

The long-term significance of Nāṭyaśāstra Gurukulam may therefore lie not merely in preserving artistic heritage, but in helping reconstruct the affective foundations of civic civilisation in an era of accelerating fragmentation. In this sense, the preservation of aesthetic civilisation may itself become indispensable to the long-term governability of democratic society.
